HMO Feasibility Document

March 2026

HMO Feasibility Summary

4 St John’s Street, Aylesbury, Buckinghamshire, HP20 1BS

1. Property and Location Overview

The property is located within the built-up area of Aylesbury, which is identified as a highly sustainable location with strong access to services, public transport, and local amenities. This aligns with recent planning decisions which support HMO intensification in similar central locations.

The site is not located within an Article 4 area, meaning there is a fallback position for a 6-bedroom HMO under permitted development, subject to confirmation through due diligence.

Local precedent is strong, with multiple approvals for 7–8 bedroom HMOs within the area, confirming that larger HMOs are acceptable in principle where design and amenity standards are met.

2. Proposed HMO Strategy

Target: 9-bedroom HMO (Sui Generis), all en-suite

The scheme has been tested at feasibility stage and demonstrates that:

- 9 bedrooms can be achieved
- All bedrooms are generously sized between 12–16 sqm
- Total communal amenity provision of approximately 25 sqm
- Amenity is split across ground floor and second floor levels

Design Approach

The layout has been deliberately designed to prioritise:

- High-quality room sizes (well above minimum standards)
- Adequate and well-distributed communal space
- Efficient circulation and logical stacking of services

Amenity Strategy (Key Planning Driver)

The communal amenity has been split across two floors rather than concentrated in a single space.

This approach has been adopted intentionally as, in our experience, Buckinghamshire Council is more receptive to larger HMOs where amenity is distributed, particularly in schemes exceeding 7 occupants.

This ensures:

- Reduced pressure on a single communal space
- Improved usability for occupants
- A stronger planning narrative demonstrating high-quality living conditions

This directly addresses the primary refusal reasons seen locally, where schemes have failed due to undersized or insufficient communal areas.

3. Design Opportunities and Key Constraints

Ground Floor Layout

The ground floor is expected to accommodate:

- Bedrooms to the front / central areas
- Primary kitchen / dining space
- Part of the communal amenity provision

The overall amenity provision across the building equates to approximately 25 sqm, which exceeds the minimum requirements identified in recent officer reports.

Upper Floors

Upper levels accommodate the majority of bedrooms, all of which:

- Are en-suite
- Exceed minimum space standards
- Benefit from natural light and appropriate outlook

Loft Space (Key Uncertainty)

The feasibility has assumed potential accommodation within the loft; however:

- The measured survey did not include confirmed head heights
- It is therefore not possible at this stage to fully verify compliance

This represents a key risk, and the following must be confirmed:

- Usable head height (2.0m+ zones ideally)
- Stair positioning feasibility
- Compliance with Building Regulations (Part B and Part K)

External Constraints (To Be Confirmed)

Further due diligence is required to confirm:

- Presence and usability of rear garden / amenity space
- Availability and arrangement of parking provision

While recent decisions indicate that parking shortfalls are not necessarily a reason for refusal in sustainable locations, this should still be understood early.

4. Planning Position and Risk

Principle of Development

- The site is located in a sustainable town centre location
- There is strong precedent for 7–8 bed HMOs
- Intensification of existing residential use is supported

Key Planning Risk

The primary risk is overdevelopment leading to poor internal amenity, not policy restriction.

Recent refusals in the area have been directly linked to:

- Undersized kitchen / dining spaces
- Insufficient communal amenity

Assessment of Proposed Scheme

The proposed 9-bedroom scheme mitigates these risks by:

- Providing larger-than-required bedroom sizes (12–16 sqm)
- Delivering 25 sqm of communal space
- Splitting amenity across floors to improve usability

Professional View

- 8-bed schemes are clearly supported and represent a safe planning position
- 9-bed is achievable but higher risk, dependent on final layout quality and spatial perception

5. Building Regulations and Technical Compliance

A conversion of this nature will trigger a full Building Regulations upgrade across the entire building, not just the areas being altered.

This is a critical consideration in both design and cost planning.

Fire Safety (Part B)

The building will require:

- Protected escape routes throughout
- Likely 60-minute fire protection to corridors and structure
- Fire doors (FD30/FD60 as required)
- Mains-wired fire alarm system (likely LD1 for large HMO)

The layout must be designed to avoid inner room scenarios and ensure compliant escape.

Acoustics (Part E)

- Upgrading of all walls and floors to achieve compliant sound separation
- Likely requirement for:
    - Resilient bar systems
    - Acoustic insulation upgrades
    - Enhanced floor build-ups

This is particularly important in larger HMOs where room stacking is intensive.

Thermal Performance (Part L)

- Upgrading of external walls, roof, and openings
- Improved insulation to meet current standards
- Potential requirement to upgrade windows and building fabric

Ventilation (Part F)

- Mechanical extract ventilation to wet rooms
- Adequate background ventilation throughout

General Implication

The key takeaway is:

This is not a light refurbishment
It is effectively a full technical upgrade of the building

This has implications for:

- Build cost
- Programme
- Design coordination

6. Commercial Position

Based on local data:

- Room rates circa £800–£850 pcm are achievable
- Larger, high-quality en-suite rooms may exceed this

A 9-bed scheme provides strong income potential, however:

- Must be balanced against increased build cost and planning risk

7. Key Next Steps

- Confirm loft head heights via detailed measured survey
- Confirm garden and parking arrangements
- Test and refine layout to ensure compliance with amenity standards
- Consider fallback 8-bed scheme as planning-safe option
- Progress to measured survey and concept design
- Engage early with Building Control if required

8. Conclusion

4 St John's Street presents a strong opportunity for a high-quality HMO conversion in a sustainable and well-supported location.

A 9-bedroom scheme is achievable at feasibility stage and performs well in terms of room sizes and amenity provision. However, it sits at the upper end of what is likely to be supported and will require careful design to avoid overdevelopment concerns.

The proposal benefits from:

- Generous room sizes
- Well-considered distributed amenity
- Strong local planning precedent

The primary constraint is not policy, but design quality and compliance, particularly in relation to communal space and overall spatial arrangement.

A refined 8-bedroom scheme remains the most robust fallback position, with the 9-bedroom option representing a higher-yield, higher-risk strategy.